accuracy and tenacity. I never saw Anil let up in intensity and have nothing but the highest regard for him, one of the greatest players to have represented India.

The ODI series was more closely contested and we went into the last match at Gwalior on 5 March 1993 needing to win to level the series. Up till then, I had had a mediocre run batting at number five or six. However, at Gwalior I managed to score a quick 34 off thirty balls at a crucial time in the game and was involved in a key partnership with Azhar, who scored a brilliant 95 not out as he took us to victory.

The England series marked the beginning of a very successful phase in Indian cricket. We followed up by beating Zimbabwe in a one-off Test at home and were gradually getting into a healthy winning habit in home conditions. In ODIs we had started winning close contests and we went into the next major one-day tournament – the Hero Cup, also featuring South Africa, Sri Lanka, the West Indies and Zimbabwe – as one of the favourites.

Turning my arm over

Not long before the Hero Cup I played a festival match in Bangalore. When Kiran More, normally a wicketkeeper, bowled me a juicy full toss I tried to hit it for six but ended up twisting my wrist. It was a freakish injury and while I was able to continue batting, I was in serious pain. After a few days the injury had still not eased and it was decided that I needed to have an injection. This was my first cortisone injection and Dr Anant Joshi flew in from Mumbai to Delhi to administer the shot. I was to be injected on my wrist very close to the palm, and with the Hero Cup just days away, I was apprehensive about the recovery. The injection, which was pretty painful, was the first of a hundred or more cortisone injections over the course of my career.

The one match of the Hero Cup I will never forget is the semi-final against South Africa on 24 November 1993. We batted first, scoring a very modest 195 in our fifty overs. We knew we needed to bowl and field exceedingly well if we were to stop South Africa from making the final. Our bowlers, led by Anil, did a very good job and at the end of the forty-ninth over South Africa needed six runs to win. Having made a match of it despite scoring too few runs, we now had to decide who should be entrusted with the task of bowling the all-important final over.